

SYNTHETIC — illustrative, not from any real company. Written for a portfolio RAG project; does not describe any real incident.

Incident Postmortem: Point-of-Sale Outage

Incident ID: POS-ERR-3021 | Date: 2026-03-18 | Severity: **SEV-2**

Summary

All registers at 14 stores lost connection to the central POS network for approximately 47 minutes during peak afternoon hours. Affected stores fell back to offline transaction mode; no sales were lost, but loyalty point accrual and gift card balance checks were unavailable for the duration.

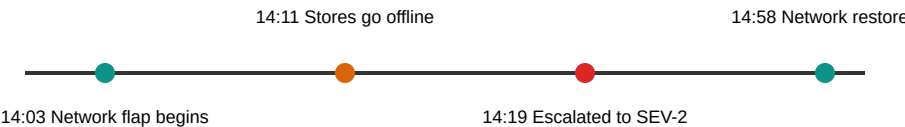


Figure 1: Incident timeline, all times local. Full restoration of loyalty/gift-card services completed 15 minutes after network restoration (15:13), not shown above.

Root Cause

A firmware update pushed to the regional network switches serving the 14 affected stores caused an intermittent routing loop under high connection volume. The update had passed staging validation, which does not replicate peak-hour connection volume — the failure mode only appeared under real traffic load, which staging environments are not currently sized to simulate.

Customer Impact

Impact area	Detail
Sales transactions	Continued via offline mode; no data loss
Loyalty point accrual	Delayed, not lost — batch-reconciled overnight per LOY-POL-001
Gift card balance checks	Unavailable; store credit accepted on associate's verbal balance estimate where customer had a recent receipt
Price-match/return processing	Deferred to next business day for the 14 stores

Interaction with Points Expiry

Several customers whose points were scheduled to expire during the outage window contacted support afterward. Per Points Expiry Policy LOY-POL-002 Section 4, points affected by a documented outage are eligible for reinstatement with a fresh 90-day expiry window if the customer contacts support within 30

days — this incident is the specific, real trigger Section 4 of that policy was written to cover, and this postmortem is the canonical incident record referenced when processing those reinstatement requests.

Corrective Actions

1. Size the staging environment to replicate realistic peak-hour connection volume before the next network firmware rollout (owner: infrastructure, target: next quarter).
2. Add automated rollback triggered by a connection-loop detection threshold, rather than relying on manual escalation to trigger rollback (owner: infrastructure).
3. Document the offline-mode fallback procedure for store associates more prominently — several stores reported associates being unsure whether offline mode was active or the register had simply frozen.

Related Documents

LOY-POL-002 — Points Expiry Policy (Section 4, outage reinstatement provision referenced above) ·
RUN-REF-001 — Failed Refund Runbook (references this incident's error code for refund-failure triage)